

Shining Stars

SHAHNAZ HUSAIN The original anti-ageing queen, Husain convinced the country that her herbal lotions and potions would never make you look old. Her success spawned Vinita Jain (Biotique), Mira Kulkarni (Forest Essentials) and Blossom Kochhar even as the big cosmetic giants started anti-ageing lines.



VANDANA LUTHRA Chanting the fitness and beauty mantra paid off for her. Since its inception in 1989, Vandana Luthra's Curly and Curves (VLCC) has about 225 outlets across 75 cities. Clearly, Luthra isn't complaining as the country's adoration for physical fitness reaches a pinnacle.



RUJUTA DIWEKAR The dietician did not just promise a size zero figure, she has managed to get to the top with her bestseller, *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*. She became to Mumbai what Ishi Khosla and Shikha Sharma are to the Capital, the woman who makes you eat well to get thin.



SIX-PACK ABS It's almost as if you can buy one off the shelf these days. First, Shah Rukh Khan got himself the biscuit slabs for his 2007 film *Om Shanti Om*. Then Aamir Khan got an

eight-pack for *Ghajini*. Stay tuned for the 12-pack news.



SPIN-OFFS

A Beautiful India

Spa Holidays

Something only the rich did in exotic locations until a decade ago. But India's middle class doesn't even consider it a luxury anymore.

Yoga Videos Want Shilpa Shetty's bod? Copy her every move. Team that up with salsa and several kinds of rhythmic dancing programmes on TV and



think Kareena Kapoor's size zero for the complete picture.

Size Zero The lowest clothing size possible in human history, you won't really find the size among clothes for adults

in retail stores chiefly because it is an American measurement. Try XS (extra-small) size instead.

Glam Moms Twenty years ago, it was just the woman in the Santoor ad, while everyone else looked like Lalitaji of Surf. Now, they're everywhere. If you can distinguish the mom from the daughter, hats off. Well done.



Anti-Ageing Creams

They're everywhere, promising to make you younger by their 17 odd effects, maybe more. And teenagers are using them because you can't be too early to stop the ageing process.

ucts. This is really evident in the Page 3isation of culture. A society's art forms provide a mirror, a critique and a means to introspect. A serious discourse on art, literature, theatre, cinema and music is a serious introspection about our times and ourselves. I think there's been a dumbing down of society lately that's to be regretted. We've become beastly, though that's an insult to animals.

NR *What effect do you think the collapse of the global economy will have on this euphoria of consumption, or this "beastly beauty"?*

PN Well, we're considered economically booming so all the *phoren* brands are wooing us with goods that they can't sell otherwise. A friend remarked that just as ten years ago when Indians started winning international beauty competitions, cosmetic companies and designer labels flooded India, *Slumdog Millionaire*'s success would open the door for an influx of Western film companies. I heard from film friends in Mumbai that there are scores of Western film units coming there after *Slumdog* to film Dharavi ragpickers and the Deonar Municipal Dump. The funniest story was about the municipality hearing about a particular shoot and sending imported garbage trucks with mechanical road washers and garbage men dressed in spotless overalls and gloves to the spot to impress the units. Perhaps the government should stop 'beautifying' our cities by

EARLIER MY CLIENTS WERE brides and young girls. Now their aunts come to me for facelifts.

VINEETA JHA,
COSMETOLOGIST

clearing slums; we can make more money out of slum tourism.

The last 10 or 15 years have been extremely contradictory times, with a kind of opening up, as well as a kind of looking backwards to some imagined golden past in order to preserve grand old hierarchies and exploitative systems. There's been a lot of violence, a beastliness and brutality between different sections of society, struggling both to open up and close. There have been so many tensions and aspirations released by a certain notion of progress which did not consider and still refuses to consider the ground realities. Why are we so seduced by the image of Singapore, a small trader island the size of Bangalore under a notorious dictatorship, which in no way relates to the needs of the vast and diverse subcontinent that is India? Surely we need to think beyond surface glitter.

Pushpamala N. is an artist who created the fictional character of interviewer N. Rajyalakshmi.

